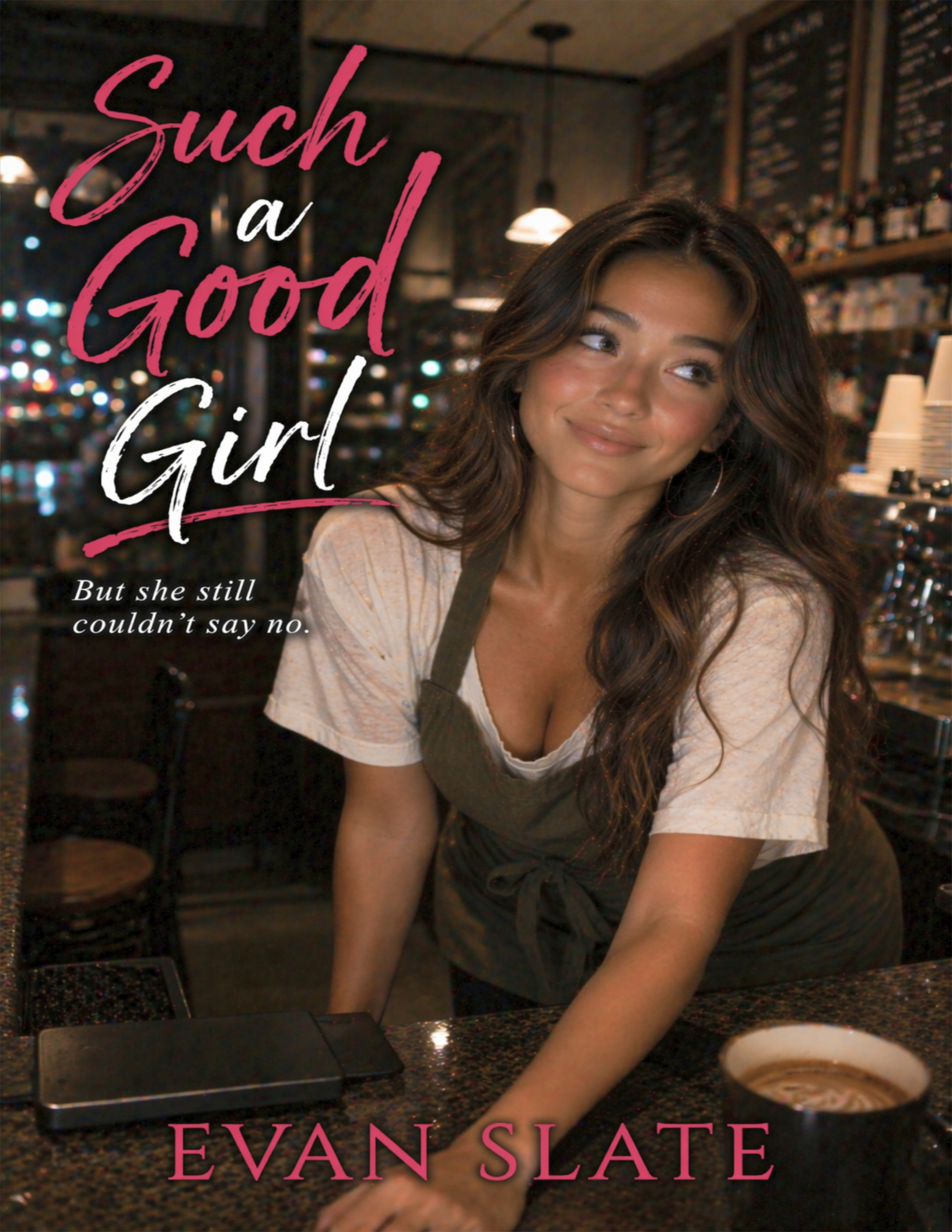




Such *a* Good Girl

*But she still
couldn't say no.*

EVAN SLATE

SUCH A GOOD GIRL

But she still couldn't say no

Evan Slate

PMI

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The espresso machine hissed its final complaint of the night as Jessa wiped down the steam wand, her reflection flashing across the stainless steel. Eight fifty-three. Seven minutes until she could flip the sign, count the drawer, and drive home to her apartment where her cat was probably already asleep on her pillow.

Her phone buzzed against the counter.

Cole: *Heading to bed, babe. Sweet dreams.*

She smiled, typing back a quick response. *Sleep well, Mister Man. Love you.* The heart emoji he'd sent was the red one, not the pink, which he reserved for special occasions. Two years of dating and she'd learned to read his emoji language like scripture. Red for routine affection, pink for moments that mattered. The purple one had appeared exactly once, the night he'd told her he was thinking about rings.

Jessa tucked the phone into her apron pocket and surveyed the empty café. Six tables, all needing a final wipe. The pastry case was already cleared, the day's unsold muffins boxed up for the shelter downtown. Chairs were half-stacked, her system for closing that probably drove the morning crew crazy but made her feel like she was making progress even while doing the tedious parts.

Through the wall, bass thumped from Rosie's Bar next door. It was Thursday night, which meant live music, which meant the vibrations would rattle the spare mugs on the back shelf until well past midnight. She'd complained once to her manager, who'd shrugged and said the building had been this way since before Jessa was born. The coffee shop had grown up next to the bar like mismatched siblings, and neither was moving.

She sprayed Table Four with sanitizer, her rag moving in efficient circles. The couple who'd lingered there for two hours nursing a single latte each had finally left around eight, and she'd found a five-dollar bill tucked under their empty cup. Guilt money, probably. She'd take it.

The music next door swelled, something with horns and a driving rhythm that made her hips want to move even though she'd never admit it. Cole didn't dance. He'd explained once that he didn't see the point of it, the way bodies moved against each other to music, the heat and the sweat of it. Too suggestive, he'd said. Too easy to let things get out of hand.

She agreed with him and of course she did, he expected no less.

The register count went quickly, it had been a slow night, more herbal teas than espressos, more people killing time than actually needing caffeine. She noted the total on the deposit slip, bundled the cash, and was reaching for the zipper bag when the door chimed.

Jessa's head snapped up. Eighty fifty-five. The OPEN sign was still lit, her own fault for not flipping it early, and now a man was standing in the doorway, all broad shoulders and dark hair, looking at the menu board like he had all the time in the world.

"We're closing in five minutes," she said, and immediately felt like a jerk. The customer service voice her manager had drilled into her demanded better. "But I can still make you something quick."

He turned to look at her, and something in her stomach did a small, inexplicable flip. He wasn't handsome in the way Cole was handsome, Cole with his clean jaw and side-parted hair and polo shirts in muted colors. This man looked like he'd just come from the bar next door, probably. A little rumpled, a few day's worth of stubble shadowing his face, eyes that were either brown or green, she couldn't tell from that distance, but they crinkled when he smiled.

"Americano," he said. "Large. And I'll get out of your hair."

"No, it's..." She stopped herself from saying *fine*, because it wasn't fine, she wanted to go home. "Coming right up."

He moved to the counter while she turned to the espresso machine, coaxing it back to life. The beans ground with a familiar whir, and she tamped them down into the portafilter with more force than necessary. Behind her, she could feel him watching. Not in a creepy way, exactly. Just... present. Taking up space in a room that had felt empty a minute ago.

"Late night?" he asked.

"Closing shift." She slid the portafilter into place and hit the button. The machine groaned, then began its slow extraction. "You?"

"Couldn't sleep. Figured caffeine was the logical solution."

She laughed before she could stop herself. "That's terrible logic."

"Never claimed to be smart."

It made one of her eyes squint. The espresso dripped into the cup, dark and thick, and she added hot water from the dispenser, filling it to the brim. When she turned to hand it to him, he was leaning against the counter, and she noticed his hands for the first time.

They were large, the knuckles scarred in places, but nails trimmed short and clean. Working hands, her mother would have called them. Hands that had done things, built things, maybe broken a few things too. A silver ring sat on his right middle finger, simple and unadorned. His left hand was bare.

She set the cup down, and his fingers brushed hers when he reached for it.

"Thanks," he said. "What do I owe you?"

"Five seventy-five."

He handed her a ten and waved off the change. "Keep it. For staying open."

"You really don't have to..."

"Yeah I do." He lifted the cup in a small salute. "You have a good night."

And then he was gone, the door chiming behind him, leaving nothing but the smell of espresso, but maybe also sandalwood, or cedar, hanging in the air where he'd stood.

Jessa realized she was still holding the ten-dollar bill. Her fingers felt warm where they'd touched.

She shook her head, tucked the money into the tip jar, and went to flip the sign to CLOSED.

Three weeks, and Jessa had started listening for the door chime at eight forty-five.

She told herself it was just awareness, simple pattern recognition. The man, Jackson, she'd learned was his name when he'd paid with a card on his third visit, came in late almost every night she worked. Not every night, that would have been too predictable, too easy to anticipate and therefore dismiss. But often enough that her body had begun to expect him, her pulse ticking up whenever the bell rang in the final hour of her shift.

Pavlov's barista, she thought bitterly, wiping espresso grounds from the portafilter.

He always ordered the same thing. Large Americano, room for nothing. He always tipped too much. And he always, without fail, made her laugh with one thing or another.

"Okay, but consider this," he said one night, leaning against the counter while she steamed milk for a decaf latte someone had ordered ten minutes before close. "What if coffee shops had bouncers?"

"Bouncers."

"Yeah. Someone to check IDs, but like, emotional IDs. 'Sorry, man, you're too stressed to order a triple shot. I'm going to need you to step outside and take some deep breaths.'"

She snorted, nearly scalding herself. "We'd lose half our customers."

"You'd be doing them a service. Public health initiative." He gestured broadly with his cup. "I should run for office on that platform."

"You'd lose."

"Spectacularly," he agreed. "But I'd have fun."

That was the thing about Jackson. He had fun. He seemed to find the whole world vaguely amusing, including himself, and that amusement was infectious in a way Jessa didn't quite know how to handle. Cole was many things, steady, reliable, faithful, but *fun* wasn't a word she'd have reached for. Cole approached life like a series of tasks to be completed correctly. Jackson approached it like a joke he was still working out the punchline for.

She'd catch herself thinking about their conversations during the day, replaying his words while she showered or drove or sat through Sunday service with Cole's hand resting on her knee. It didn't mean anything. People thought about things. That was just how brains worked.

It doesn't mean anything.

Cole picked her up on a Tuesday, two weeks into Jackson's regular appearances. She'd mentioned her car was making a noise, something in the engine that whined when she accelerated, and he'd insisted on driving her until she could get it looked at. That was Cole. Protective. Practical. The kind of man who noticed problems and fixed them without being asked.

He was waiting in the parking lot when she locked up, his sensible sedan idling under the streetlight. She slid into the passenger seat, and he leaned over to kiss her cheek, his lips dry and familiar.

"How was it?"

"Slow. Mostly just me and the espresso machine having a staring contest."

He smiled, pulling out of the lot. "Who won?"

"Undecided. Rematch tomorrow."

The door to Rosie's Bar was flung open as they passed, spilling light and noise out onto the sidewalk, and Jessa saw Jackson step out. He was wearing a black t-shirt, a towel thrown over one shoulder, and he lifted a hand in a wave when he spotted her through the windshield.

She waved back before she could think about it.

"Who's that?" Cole asked, glancing in the rearview mirror, his brows creased instantly.

"Just a customer. He comes in sometimes."

"Ah." Cole's voice went neutral, unconcerned again. Why would he be concerned? The man was just a customer. A stranger. Someone who existed on the periphery of her life and would stay there.

"He tips well," she added, though Cole hadn't asked.

"That's nice of him."

And that was it. The conversation moved on, shifted to Cole's day at work, the project he was managing, the coworker who kept missing deadlines. Jackson faded into the background noise of her life, unexamined and unthreatening. Where it belonged.

She thought about that later, how easy it was for Cole to dismiss the man. How completely Jackson had failed to register as anything worth noticing for him.

It should have been reassuring.

The third week, Jackson came in earlier than usual. It was eight-fifteen, the café still half-full, and Jessa fumbled a simple drip coffee order because she hadn't expected to see him standing in her line. He waited patiently, scrolling through his phone, and when he reached the counter, his smile was the same as always.

"Americano?"

"You know me so well."

She rang him up, their fingers brushing over the card reader, and she absolutely did not think about the warmth of his skin.

"Slow night?" he asked, glancing around.

"Getting there. The rush ended about an hour ago."

"Good. Means I get you to myself."

He said it casually, like it meant nothing, but something in her chest tightened. She turned to make his drink, grateful for the excuse to hide her

face which heated up faster than the water.

"So," he said behind her, "three weeks of late-night caffeine, and I just realized I never asked. What do you do when you're not saving insomniacs from themselves?"

"Not much." She pulled the espresso shot, watching the dark liquid drip into the cup. "I read. Go to church. Hang out with my boyfriend."

"The guy who picked you up last week?"

She glanced over her shoulder. "You noticed that?"

"Hard not to. He drives like someone's grandpa."

"He drives *safely*," she grinned and rolled her eyes.

"Same thing." Jackson grinned, unrepentant. "He seems nice."

"He is."

"Good. You seem like someone who'd end up with someone nice."

She wasn't sure if that was a compliment or not. She finished his Americano and set it on the counter, and he wrapped those scarred knuckles around the cup like he was holding something precious.

"You know," he said, "I've been meaning to mention. I actually work next door."

"At Rosie's?"

"Bartender. Four nights a week, sometimes five if someone calls out." He took a sip of his coffee, watching her over the rim. "You ever want to come in after your shift... For a drink..."

Jessa shook her head. "I don't drink."

She waited for the reaction she usually got, the raised eyebrows, the *really?*, the polite confusion of someone who couldn't imagine life without alcohol as a social lubricant. Cole didn't drink either, which was one of the things that had drawn her to him initially. He was the rare man who didn't need substances to relax, who could be present and clearheaded at all times. It was rare, and it mattered to her.

But Jackson just nodded, like she'd told him something completely unremarkable.

"Makes sense," he said.

And then he smiled.

It wasn't his usual smile, the one that crinkled his eyes and invited her to laugh at whatever joke he was setting up. This was slower, softer, like he was seeing something in her that she hadn't meant to show, and he liked what he found.

Jessa felt the heat rise to her face again before she could stop it. Her cheeks burned, and she knew, she *knew*, he could see it, could see exactly what his smile was doing to her.

"I should..." She gestured vaguely at the café behind her, the tables that needed wiping, the tasks that suddenly seemed incredibly urgent. "Closing stuff."

"Yeah." He stepped back from the counter, still smiling. "See you tomorrow, Jessa."

He said her name like he'd been practicing it. Like he'd been thinking about how it would feel in his mouth.

She didn't answer. She just turned around and busied herself with the espresso machine, and she didn't look up again until the door chimed and he was gone.

Her phone buzzed.

Cole: Thinking about you. Sleep well tonight. ❤️

She stared at the red heart for a long moment.

Then she put the phone away and went to wipe down tables that were already clean.

Friday arrived like a held breath.

Cole had left Thursday evening, his overnight bag packed with the careful precision he applied to everything. Three shirts, two pairs of pants, his Bible with the worn leather cover, the devotional journal she'd given him for Christmas. He'd kissed her at her apartment door, his hand resting on her hip in that careful way he had, present but restrained, conscious of boundaries even when no one was watching.

"I'll miss you," he said.

"It's two days."

"Still." He smiled, that sweet Cole smile that had made her feel safe for two years. "Call me before bed?"

"Of course."

She watched his taillights disappear around the corner and told herself the flutter in her stomach was just the strangeness of being alone. She'd grown used to his texts, his check-ins, the steady rhythm of his presence even when they were apart. A weekend without him shouldn't feel like freedom.

And it didn't feel like freedom.

It felt like *possibility*, which was worse.

Friday's shift dragged and raced in equal measure. Every hour felt too long; every glance at the clock showed time had leaped forward without her noticing. Jackson didn't come in during the evening, and she told herself she wasn't disappointed, she wasn't watching the door, she wasn't aware of the absence of his particular weight in the room.

At eleven, she counted the drawer. Locked the register. Wiped down the espresso machine and stacked the chairs and did everything she was supposed to do in exactly the order she was supposed to do it in.

Then she stood in the parking lot, keys in hand, and looked at the glowing sign for Rosie's Bar.

I'm twenty-five, she thought. Twenty-four. Whatever. I'm an adult. I'm allowed to go to a bar.

She'd never been to a bar, not even once. Her mother had raised her on stories of dark rooms and bad decisions, men who smelled like whiskey and wanted things good girls didn't give. Cole's family was the same way, his parents didn't even keep wine in the house for cooking. Alcohol was a door, they said. You opened it a crack, and sin came flooding through.

But Jessa didn't drink. She'd just order a Coke. She'd see what all the fuss was about, and then she'd go home and call Cole and tell him about her boring evening, and none of it would mean anything.

She crossed the parking lot before she could change her mind.

Rosie's was louder inside than she'd expected, the music wrapping around her like a physical thing. Not unpleasant, just overwhelming, after hours of coffee shop quiet. The lights were low and warm, amber bottles glowing behind the bar, and the crowd was thicker than she'd anticipated for a Friday at eleven. People clustered at tables, leaned against walls, moved against each other on a small dance floor she hadn't known existed.

And there, behind the bar, was Jackson.

He spotted her before she could decide whether to stay or flee. His face did something complicated, a surprise, then pleasure, then a grin that made her stomach flip the way it had that first night.

He gestured to an empty stool at the end of the bar, and she made her way toward it like she was wading through water.

"Well," he said, setting a napkin in front of her. "Look what the espresso machine dragged in."

"I was just curious." She slid onto the stool, hyperaware of her coffee-stained apron still shoved in her bag, the way she probably smelled like old

grounds and sanitizer. "About what all the noise was about."

"The noise is my livelihood. What can I get you?"

"Just a Coke."

He raised an eyebrow. "Just a Coke."

"I told you, I don't drink."

"You did mention that." He grabbed a glass, filled it with ice, and pulled the soda gun with the practiced ease of someone who'd done it ten thousand times. "But I figured that was just coffee shop talk. Like when people say they're doing fine."

"It wasn't."

He set the Coke in front of her, and his fingers lingered on the glass for just a moment. "Then just a Coke it is. On the house."

"You don't have to..."

"I know." He smiled. "Drink up, church girl."

She should have been offended by that. Church girl. The way he said it, like he could see right through her, like he'd clocked her the moment she walked in and filed her away under *wholesome* and *off-limits* and *not for him*. But the way he said it wasn't mocking. It was almost... fond.

She drank her Coke and watched him work.

Jackson behind a bar was different from Jackson in her coffee shop. There, he was a customer, someone on the receiving end of service. Here, he was in control. He moved with an economy of motion that was almost hypnotic, reaching for bottles without looking, pouring with one hand while taking payment with the other, carrying on three conversations at once without ever losing track of any of them.

And he kept coming back to her, too.

Between orders, he'd drift to her end of the bar and lean against the counter, asking her questions that made her laugh despite herself. Where she grew up (Ohio, a small town). What she studied in college (English, because she'd loved books and hadn't known what else to do with that love). Whether she actually enjoyed working at the coffee shop or just tolerated it (both, depending on the day).

"What about you?" she asked, an hour in, her second Coke sweating on the napkin. "How'd you end up behind a bar like this?"

He gazed around like a price surveying his lands. "The usual way. Couldn't make rent, knew a guy who knew a guy, turned out I was good at

making people feel comfortable spending money." He shrugged. "It's not forever. Just until I figure shit out."

"That's very philosophical." She was joking.

"I'm a very philosophical guy." He grinned. "Also, I dropped out of college after one semester, so bartending was kind of the obvious fallback."

"What were you studying?"

"Philosophy."

She blurted out laughing and covered her face with her hand. He looked at her like her laughter was something he wanted to keep.

The hours slipped by in a way that felt almost illegal. Midnight came and went. The crowd thinned, couples stumbling out into the night, the music softening as the DJ switched to something slower. Cole hadn't texted yet, probably in some prayer circle, some bonding exercise, surrounded by other men who'd committed to purity and purpose and the narrow path.

She should text him, she thought, she should check in, hear his voice, remind herself of who she was and who she'd promised to be.

But her phone stayed in her bag.

At one, the last stragglers filtered out, and a server began stacking chairs. Jackson tossed his bar rag into a bin and leaned against the counter, looking at her with an expression she couldn't quite read.

"So," he said. "How was your first bar experience?"

"Anti-climatic," she admitted. "I expected more sin." She snorted.

"Give it time." His smile was slow, almost lazy. "The sin usually shows up after hours."

She should have gotten off the stool then and said goodnight, driven home, crawled into bed with her phone pressed to her ear and Cole's voice murmuring sleepy reassurances to her. That was what a good girlfriend did, a good Christian girl, the type who knew where the lines were and didn't cross them.

But Jackson was looking at her like she was the most interesting thing he'd seen all night, and her body felt warm in a way that had nothing to do with the ambient heat of the bar.

"Hey," he said. "You want to see my vinyl collection upstairs?"

The line was so obvious, so absurdly transparent, that she laughed and put her finger on her upper lip. A vinyl collection. At one in the morning. It was the kind of thing even her mother didn't have to warn her about, the kind of invitation that had only one meaning, and they both knew it.

But Jackson delivered it with such a self-aware half-smile, it was like he knew how ridiculous it sounded, like he was daring her to call him out on it. The obviousness was the joke, and she was invited to laugh at it with him, him smirking as though daring her.

"Your vinyl collection," she repeated deadpan.

"I have over two hundred records. It's genuinely impressive."

"Oh, I'm sure it is."

"I'm not kidding. The Fleetwood Mac collection alone is worth the trip."

She looked at him, at his scarred hands resting on the bar, at his eyes that were definitely green in this light, at the way he was giving her every opportunity to say no while making it very clear he hoped she wouldn't.

Say no, she told herself. Go home. Call Cole.

"Fine," she said. "So show me."

Jackson's smile widened and something in her chest cracked like a door she'd meant to never unlock.

The staircase was narrow and dim, tucked behind a door she'd assumed was a supply closet. Jackson went first, keys jangling in his hand, and Jessa followed with her heart thudding so loud she was sure he could hear it. Each step creaked under her feet like a warning she was choosing to ignore.

His apartment was exactly what she'd expected and nothing like it at the same time.

Small, barely bigger than her living room and kitchen combined. The ceiling sloped at odd angles, evidence of the building's age, and exposed brick dominated one wall. But the mess wasn't chaos. It was accumulation. Stacks of books on the floor beside an overstuffed armchair. A guitar propped in the corner, its case open and lined with picks. Mugs on the coffee table, some empty, one holding pens. And records. Everywhere, records. Crates of them lined against the walls, sleeves fanned out on shelves, a turntable occupying pride of place on a low console that looked older than both of them.

"Told you," Jackson said, catching her expression. "Genuinely impressive."

"You weren't lying, actually."

"I never lie about vinyl. It's sacred."

He moved through the space with the ease of someone who knew exactly where everything was despite the apparent disorder. Jessa stood just inside the door, arms crossed over her chest, suddenly aware of how alone

they were. No one knew she was here. Cole thought she was home, asleep, dreaming whatever dreams good girlfriends dreamed.

"You can sit," Jackson said, gesturing toward the couch, a deep green velvet thing that looked like it had been rescued from a vintage store. "I don't bite."

That's not what I'm worried about, she thought, but she sat anyway, perching on the edge like she might need to flee at any moment.

He crouched in front of the record crates, fingers walking across the spines with practiced familiarity. "Any requests? I've got everything from Motown to post-punk. Some jazz if you're feeling sophisticated. Country if you want to cry."

"I don't really know music," she admitted. "I mean, I know *music*, but not..." She gestured at the collection. "Not like this."

He looked over his shoulder at her, curious. "What did you grow up listening to?"

"Christian songs? Mom thought secular music was a gateway to..." She trailed off, embarrassed by it all now.

"A gateway to what?"

"Worldliness. Whatever that means..."

Jackson nodded slowly, like she'd just told him something important. He pulled a record from the crate, slid it from its sleeve with careful reverence, and set it on the turntable. The needle dropped with a soft crackle, and then...

Music. But music not like anything she'd heard before. A woman's voice, low and smoky, backed by piano and something that might have been a saxophone. It was slow and aching and impossibly intimate, like overhearing someone's private confession.

"Nina Simone," Jackson said, straightening. "Seemed right."

He moved to the kitchen, which was barely a kitchen, just a counter and a mini fridge and a hot plate, and poured himself whiskey from a bottle on the shelf. He held it up, questioning, and she shook her head.

"Still don't drink."

"Still respect that." He came to sit beside her on the couch, not too close, but close enough that she could smell him, that sandalwood again, mixed with the faint smoke of the bar. "So. Christian radio and hymns. What else don't I know about you?"

"That's pretty much it." She laughed, but it came out nervous. "I'm not very interesting."

"Hard disagree."

"You don't know me."

"I know you work closing shifts and never complain about it. I know you remember everyone's order, not just mine. I know you laughed at my terrible coffee shop bouncer joke when you could have just smiled politely." He took a sip of his whiskey, watching her over the rim. "I know you're here, in my apartment, at one in the morning, even though everything about you screams you shouldn't be."

She didn't have a response to that. The truth of it sat between them, undeniable.

"So tell me about this sheltered childhood," he said, leaning back into the couch cushions. "I want to picture it, little Jessa."

So she told him.

She told him about the church in Ohio, the one her family had attended since before she was born, about Sunday services that stretched for hours, potlucks where the women compared modest dress patterns, youth groups where they signed purity pledges and wore rings to remind them of the promises they'd made. She told him about her mother's rules, no secular music, no PG-13 movies until she was actually thirteen, no dating until college and even then only with chaperones.

"Chaperones," Jackson repeated. "Like, another person in the room?"

"Not in the room. But, you know. Around. Keeping an eye on things."

"Things."

"Hands," she clarified, and felt her face heat up. "Making sure hands stayed where they were supposed to stay." She looked sharply at him.

He was quiet for a moment, swirling the whiskey in his glass. The record had moved on to another song, still slow, still aching.

"That sounds exhausting," he finally said.

"It was normal. It's still..." She stopped. "Cole's family is the same way. That's part of why we work. We understand each other."

"Cole." Jackson said the name carefully, like he was tasting it. "The safe driver."

"He's a good man."

"I'm sure he is."

There was no judgment in his voice, but something in it made her want to defend Cole anyway, to list all his virtues like evidence in a trial. Instead, she turned the question back on him.

"What about you? What's your story?"

Jackson laughed, but it was different from his usual laugh, shorter, with an edge to it. "My story's messier. You sure you want it?"

"Fair's fair." She swung her leg from where it hung over her other knee and kicked his shin and decided she'd play it like she meant to.

He drained the rest of his whiskey and set the glass on the coffee table, empty. "I've been married. We were young, twenty-two, which is too young for anyone, but especially for me. Her name was Diana. We met in college, the one semester I actually attended, and we thought we were the real thing. Moved in together, got engaged, did the whole wedding with the white dress and the crying relatives."

"What happened?"

"Life happened. Turns out I wasn't very good at being a husband. Worked too hard, drank too much, didn't know how to fight without making everything worse." He shrugged, but his shoulders stayed tense. "She left when I was twenty-five. Divorced by twenty-seven. Haven't talked to her in two years."

"I'm sorry."

"Don't be. She was right to leave. I was a mess." He looked at her, his green eyes soft in the low light. "I'm less of a mess now. Still working on it."

Jessa didn't know what to say to that. Her whole life, she'd been taught that divorce was failure, was sin, was the breaking of a sacred covenant. But sitting here, listening to Jackson talk about it, all she could see was a man who'd made mistakes and was trying to learn from them. That didn't seem like failure. That seemed like the hardest kind of courage.

Nina Simone sang on, her voice filling the silence between them.

"Can I ask you something?" Jackson said.

"Okay."

He turned toward her, his knee almost touching hers. "Why are you here? Really?"

She opened her mouth to answer, to say she was curious, to say she wanted to see the records, to say anything that would make this seem innocent and explicable, but nothing came out.

Why was she here?

The truth was too big to say out loud. The truth was that Cole had never made her feel like this, this hum under her skin, this awareness of another body in space. The truth was that she'd been following rules her whole life and she didn't know anymore if they were protecting her or trapping her. And here was a man with no apparent rules at all, at least none like she'd known them to be.

"I don't know," she whispered.

Jackson nodded slowly. Then, very quietly, he asked:

"Can I kiss you?"

The question hung in the air like something fragile.

She knew she should stand up, apologize, walk down those narrow stairs and drive home and pretend none of this had ever happened. She should call Cole, confess, beg forgiveness from him and from God and from everyone who'd ever trusted her to be good. Causing a man to want to kiss you was pretty much as bad as kissing him.

But Cole never asked. That was the thing she kept snagging on. Cole just kissed her, gentle, chaste, appropriate, and she received it because that was what girlfriends did. But no one ever asked her what she *wanted*. No one had ever made it a question she was allowed to answer yes or no to.

"Yes," she said, an assertive act of defiance before she finally found her voice.

Jackson leaned in.

His mouth met hers like a question, soft at first, tentative and testing. Jessa had been kissed before, of course, Cole kissed her goodbye, kissed her hello, kissed her on New Year's Eve with his hands firmly on her waist, but this was different. This kiss had patience in it, and underneath the patience, mounting hunger.

Jackson's hand came up to cup her jaw, his thumb tracing the line of her cheekbone, and she heard herself make a sound. It was a small thing, barely an audible breath, but he caught it. He drew back just far enough to look at her.

"You good?"

She nodded, not trusting her voice anymore.

He kissed her again, deeper this time, his tongue sliding against hers in a way that made heat come to her belly. She'd read about this in books, secular books, hidden under her mattress in high school, devoured in guilty

secret, but reading about it and feeling it were different languages entirely. Her body was responding in ways she couldn't control, her breath coming faster, her hands reaching for him.

"Slowly," he murmured against her mouth. "We've got time tonight." Her head went light with what she heard herself saying.

He guided her backward until she was lying back against the couch cushions, and then he was above her, his weight braced on one arm, the other hand tracing her down her side. Even through her shirt, she could feel the heat of his palm. He found the hem, and his fingers slipped underneath, touching her bare skin, and she gasped.

"It's okay?"

She closed her eyes. "Yes."

He took his time with her shirt, pushing it up inch by inch, his mouth following the slow lazy path his hands took. He kissed her stomach, the dip of her navel, the curve of her ribs. Each press of his lips was cautious, exploratory, like he was learning the geography of her body. When he finally pulled the shirt over her head, she fought the urge to cover herself with her arms. But why should she? The man had gone further with her in 20 minutes than Cole had in 2 years.

Her bra was black, plain cotton, nothing special, she hadn't planned this, of course, hadn't imagined anyone would see it, but Jackson looked at her like she was wearing silk.

"So fucking beautiful," he said, and the word sounded true. "Sorry," he quickly said, and he made as though pushing the word back in his mouth.

"It's okay," she said more with breath than with voice, quickly shaking her head. An impatience was taking her over.

He kissed the swell of her breasts above the fabric of her bra, his stubble rasping against her sensitive skin. One hand slid behind her back, finding the clasp, and she arched up into him without thinking, letting him undo it. The bra fell away, and then his mouth was on her nipple, hot and wet, and she cried out.

"Shh." He smiled against her skin. "Neighbors." His grin was evil, was fun.

She bit her lip, trying to stay quiet, but it was impossible. Every touch sent sparks through her nervous system, sensations she'd never experienced, never allowed herself to imagine. Cole's hands had never wandered below

her collarbone. Cole believed in boundaries, in waiting, in saving the good stuff for marriage like dessert you had to earn. And so did she.

But this didn't feel like dessert. This felt like a revelation.

Jackson worked his way down her body with agonizing patience. She kicked her feet. He unzipped her jeans, peeled them inside out down her legs, leaving her in nothing but cotton underwear that was already embarrassingly wet. She expected him to comment, but he just pressed a kiss to her hipbone and looked up at her through dark lashes. She uncovered her hands from where they cupped over her down there, hiding herself. Let him see, a voice in her mind urged her.

"You ever done this before?"

"Done what exactly?" His pursed-lip grin was answer enough.

He hooked his fingers under the waistband of her underwear and pulled them down slowly, watching her face change the whole time, like someone leaving out over a high cliff.

She should have felt exposed and vulnerable. But the way he was looking at her made her feel powerful instead, like her body was something valuable, something worth this level of attention.

When his mouth found her, she nearly flew up off the couch hips first.

She'd heard about this, of course, whispered about at sleepovers, referenced in those hidden books, but nothing had prepared her for the reality of it. His tongue moved against her in slow, lazy strokes, and her hips bucked up involuntarily, seeking more pressure, more contact, more everything. He gripped her thighs to hold her shaking steady, and the strength in his hands made her moan and push harder.

"That's god," he murmured against her. "You feel that?"

Feel it? She was burning up under the fire of it. She couldn't have stopped feeling it if she wanted to. The pleasure built like a wave, cresting higher with every movement of his tongue. He was above her, then down the sides of her, then over top of her, then inside the folds of her. Her whole body convulsed, her back arching, her hands tugging in his hair, and she began crying, tears in her eyes, because she hadn't known it could feel like this. The convulsion was all-consuming.

But he wasn't done.

He worked a finger inside her while she was still trembling from the aftershocks, and she gasped at the intrusion. It didn't hurt, she was so wet it slid in easily, but it was new, foreign, a fullness she'd never experienced. He

curved his finger, finding a spot inside her that made her see stars, and she arched slowly and far, forgetting to breathe.

"There," he said. "Right there, right?"

She contorted so far, she was on her head facing backward and slapping the cushions, her hair whipping wildly over her face. She felt like her eyes went so far back in her head they came around again.

He added a second finger, stretching her gently, his thumb now circling her enlarged clit while he worked her further open, gently spreading her legs wider. She was writhing against his hand, chasing the sensation, and when she came again, it was deeper than before, rolling through her in waves that left her gasping. Her hips shook like electricity, and rammed upward into his hand, her body convulsing over and over and twisting side to side over the couch like storm waves tossing a useless boat.

Then he was pulling her up, repositioning them both until she was straddling his lap. He was still clothed, and she realized belatedly that she hadn't even touched him yet. But she could feel the hardened length of him through his jeans. She rolled her bared and soaking hips instinctively, grinding down against him, and his groan was the most satisfying sound she'd ever heard. It made her grit her teeth and push her chest up.

"Go," he breathed. "Take me on."

She did. She rocked against him faster and harder, finding an angle that made her clit drag against his rough denim, the friction was almost too much. His hands gripped her hips and guided her rhythm, and she rode him like that, clothes technically between them from the waist down, technically not breaking her promise, technically still virtuous in the narrowest possible definition of the word.

He pushed up against her from below and she collapsed suddenly again, drained and falling against his chest, her whole body shaking out of control.

Jackson held her, one hand stroking her back, his heartbeat thundering under her ear. She could feel him still hard beneath her, of course, unsatisfied, but he made no move to take anything from her.

"You still good?" he asked softly directly into her ear.

Jessa lifted her swooning head. Her cheeks were streaked with tears, her hair was a disaster, but she'd never felt more alive in her entire life.

"I didn't know," she whispered and she laughed at herself. "I didn't know it could be like that."

It was him who handed her her bra and panties and insisted she dress. She thought he was kidding, but he wasn't.

The drive home was quiet, the streets empty, her body still humming like a plucked string.

She gripped the steering wheel and stared at the road, but she wasn't even seeing it. She was still on that green velvet couch, still feeling Jackson's mouth between her thighs, still hearing herself make sounds she hadn't known she was capable of making. The girl who'd walked into that Rosie's Bar at eleven o'clock was not the same girl driving home at three in the morning, and she didn't know what to do about it.

Her apartment was dark when she let herself in. Luna, her gray tabby, chirped a sleepy greeting from the couch but didn't bother to get up. Everything was exactly as she'd left it, dishes in the drying rack, her Bible on the nightstand, Cole's photo smiling at her from the bookshelf, but the normalcy of it felt obscene.

She went straight to the bathroom and turned the shower as hot as she could stand it.

The water sluiced over her skin, and she scrubbed herself methodically, watching the suds spiral down the drain. She wasn't washing Jackson off. She was trying to understand how her body could still feel so electric, so *alive*, long after he'd stopped touching her. Every nerve ending seemed to be firing at random, sending little aftershocks of pleasure through her system whenever she moved.

It wasn't cheating.

She repeated it like a prayer, like a confession, like a lie she was trying to make true.

We didn't have sex. He never even took off his pants. I'm still a virgin. I kept my promise.

The technicality felt thin though even as she clung to it. She'd come three times on a stranger's couch while her boyfriend prayed at a retreat, and she was trying to argue that it didn't count because there was no penetration. The logic was absurd and she knew it.

But she couldn't make herself feel guilty, though she scoured herself for it. That was the worst part. She kept waiting for the shame to hit, the crushing weight of conviction she'd been taught would follow any sexual sin. She'd heard testimonies at youth group, girls who'd gone too far and wept at the altar, begging God's forgiveness, describing the emptiness and

regret that followed their mistakes. Jessa had nodded along, had believed them, had thanked God that she'd never have to feel that way because she was *good*, she was *careful*, she was saving herself for the man she'd marry.

Now she stood in her shower at three in the morning, and all she felt was totally, bewitchingly, alive.

She couldn't sleep, of course. She lay in bed staring at the ceiling, replaying every moment in excruciating detail. The way Jackson had asked permission. The way he'd watched her face while he touched her, adjusting his rhythm based on her responses, learning her body like a language he wanted to become fluent in. The way he'd held her afterward, not pushing for more, not making her feel like she owed him anything. The way he was the one who sent her home... Not for lack of desire, she well knew, but because of a gush of it.

Cole had never made her feel anything like that. Cole made her feel safe, yes, protected, sure, cherished, even, but in a distant sort of way. He'd never made her feel *taken*.

Sunday passed in a haze. She went to church alone, her usual service, and sat in the back, mouthing the words to songs she'd known since childhood. The pastor preached about temptation, because of course he did, and Jessa stared at her hands and thought about Jackson's fingers inside her.

God, I'm sorry she thought

But she wasn't. That was the thing, she wasn't sorry at all.

Cole texted her around four.

Heading home soon. Can't wait to see you. The weekend was amazing.

She typed back: *Can't wait to hear about it. Love you.*

The words felt like someone else's now and she stared at them like they were some foreign language before she sent them.

He showed up at her apartment around seven, still wearing the polo shirt he'd left in, his face bright with that particular glow of wholesome spiritual fulfillment. Jessa opened the door, and he pulled her into a hug that smelled like campfire smoke and communion grape juice.

"I missed you," he said into her hair.

"Missed you too." She knew she glowed with something else, and worried she smelled differently too.

They sat on her couch, not a green velvet couch, but a beige IKEA thing she'd bought when she moved in, and Cole told her about his weekend, the bonding exercises, the small group discussions, the moment during late

Saturday night worship when he'd felt God's presence so strongly he'd cried. His eyes shone as he described it, his hands moving with unusual animation, and Jessa nodded and smiled and made the right sounds at the right times.

She realized it was right about that time...

"Pastor Williams talked about covenant," Cole said. "About how marriage is a reflection of Christ's love for the church. It really made me think about us, you know? About our future."

"That's beautiful."

"I know we've talked about waiting until I'm more established at work, but..." He took her hand, his thumb tracing over her knuckles. "I've been praying about it, and I think maybe we shouldn't wait too much longer. We've been together two years. We know this is right."

Jessa's stomach dropped.

"Cole..."

"I'm not proposing right now," he added quickly. "I know that's not romantic, just blurting it out on a Sunday night. But I wanted you to know I'm thinking about it. That this weekend made me sure."

She should have felt joy. This was what she'd been waiting for, what she'd built her whole life around, a godly man who loved her, who wanted to commit to her, who would give her the wedding and the marriage and the permission to finally have sex without guilt.

But all she could think was: *He's never made me come. He's never even tried.*

"That's..." Her voice caught. "That's a lot to take in."

"I know. Just think about it, though." He squeezed her hand. "Pray about it. I think God's got good things planned for us."

They watched a movie after that, something wholesome, something Cole had picked, and Jessa leaned against his shoulder and felt like a stranger in her own body. When the credits rolled, Cole checked his watch and said he should get going. Early morning tomorrow, big meeting at work, he needed his rest.

At the door, he cupped her face in his hands and kissed her goodnight.

It was the same kiss he always gave her, gentle, brief, closed-mouth. His lips pressed against hers for exactly two seconds, and then he pulled back, smiling that sweet Cole smile, utterly unaware that he was touching a woman who'd spent Saturday night grinding on another man's lap.

"Love you," he said.

"Love you too."

She closed the door behind him and pressed her back against it, breathing hard.

The kiss had felt like nothing, like habit, like obligation fulfilled.

All she could feel was the ghost of Jackson's hands sliding up her thighs, Jackson's mouth on her neck, Jackson's voice in her ear murmuring. Her body remembered every detail with perfect clarity, yet Cole's chaste goodbye had already faded like it had never happened.

She slid down the door until she was sitting on the floor, her knees pulled up to her chest.

What am I even doing?

She didn't have an answer and she wasn't sure she wanted one.

It became a rhythm, as natural and inevitable as breathing.

Tuesday nights, Cole had Bible study. Thursday nights, men's group. Every other Saturday, he volunteered at the church food pantry. And Jessa, dutiful girlfriend, faithful Christian, all-round good girl, found herself climbing the narrow stairs behind Rosie's Bar with a regularity that should have shaken her.

But it didn't.

The first few times, she told herself it was curiosity. She was exploring, that was all. Learning what her body could do. Jackson was patient and thorough and never pushed for more than she was willing to give, which somehow made her willing to give more each time. She learned the geography of his apartment, which floorboard creaked, how his lamps cast shadows, which records he put on when he wanted to make her fall apart all over again for him.

The man knew his music.

Nina Simone was for slow nights, when he took his time with his mouth and fingers and made her come so many times she had no count. Fleetwood Mac was for desperate nights, when she climbed into his lap and ground herself against him until they were both panting. Once, he put on something with heavy bass and fucked her with his fingers against the wall while she bit his shoulder to keep from screaming.

She learned things about herself she'd never otherwise have known., that she loved her hair pulled, if gently, usually. That the inside of her elbow was surprisingly sensitive. That she could come just from nipple stimulation

if Jackson was patient enough, and Jackson was always patient enough. Her body, which she'd spent twenty-five years treating like a vessel for her soul, revealed itself to be an instrument capable of symphonies she'd never imagined, and Jackson the constant musician who played her

And still, technically, she was a virgin.

The technicality mattered. It *had* to matter. She clung to it like a life raft, reminding herself every time she drove home with her thighs still shaking that she hadn't broken her promise, not in any way that truly counted. She'd never felt him inside her, though she'd felt the shape of him through his jeans a hundred times, had learned exactly how to roll her hips to make him groan. She'd never seen him fully naked, either, though she'd memorized every inch of his chest, his stomach, the trail of dark hair that disappeared below his waistband. She'd opened his belt and pants and drawn down his fly but that was all.

Lines existed and she was staying on the right side of them.

But barely, whispered a voice in her head. *By a technicality so thin it might as well not exist.*

She got better at lying.

"How was your night?" Cole would ask, and she'd say "Quiet, just stayed in" with a smile that never wavered. "You seem different lately," he observed once, and she laughed and blamed it on the new vitamins she was taking. "More energy," she said. "I've been sleeping better."

But she hadn't been sleeping at all.

The guilt came in waves, unpredictable and fleeting. She'd be sitting in church and suddenly feel the weight of her hypocrisy pressing down on her chest, making it hard to breathe. She'd see Cole's face across a restaurant table and want to confess everything, to fall on her knees and beg for forgiveness the way those girls at youth group had described.

But then she'd be back in Jackson's apartment, and the guilt would evaporate like morning fog. She'd be underneath him on that green velvet couch, his mouth on her throat, his fingers working her toward another shattering climax, and she couldn't remember why she'd ever felt bad about any of it.

Jackson never asked about Cole. He never asked about the future, or what they were doing, or whether she planned to keep splitting herself between two lives forever. He just welcomed her when she showed up and

let her leave when she needed to, and something about that lack of pressure made her keep coming back.

"You're getting good at this," he said one night, his voice rough as she rode his thigh, chasing her third orgasm of the evening.

"Good at what?"

"Taking what you want."

She came so hard she saw stars, and afterward, lying completely naked like she enjoyed the most, and boneless on his chest, she thought about what it meant that she'd needed a stranger to teach her about her own body. She drew circles in the thin hairs on his chest, kissed his nipple, sank her mouth over his, wrestled his tongue with hers and laughed.

She pushed him on his back, straddled his chest and when he asked, she pinched his lips closed. Saying nothing herself, she waddled on her knees up his body, pulled her hair back over her shoulder to see down, and slowly bent at her knees and waist until her lips down there, nearly dripping with anticipation, kissed his lips up there.

The rest was a blur of trembling sensation until she could take no more.

Five weeks passed like water through fingers.

Cole didn't notice anything. Or if he did, he attributed her distraction to work stress, to seasonal changes, to the normal fluctuations of a long-term relationship. He kissed her the same way he always had, brief, chaste, controlled, and she received his kisses the same way she always had, which was with the growing awareness that they meant nothing to her.

She was a liar. She was a cheat. She was going to hell, probably, if hell existed the way her mother had always described it. But she couldn't stop. She couldn't say no.

On a Wednesday evening, six weeks into her double life, Cole texted her and asked if he could come over. Something in the message felt different, more formal than his usual casual check-ins, but she told him yes and spent the next hour cleaning her apartment and trying not to think about the fact that she'd been at Jackson's place the night before, wearing nothing but his open flannel shirt but for one button, while he made her breakfast at two in the morning.

Cole arrived at seven, and he was nervous.

She could tell immediately. His hands kept finding his pockets and leaving them again. His smile was too bright, too fixed. He sat on her

couch, the beige IKEA one, not the green velvet one that featured in her dreams, and patted the cushion beside him.

"I need to talk to you about something."

Jessa's stomach dropped. For one wild moment, she was certain he knew. Someone had seen her at Rosie's, someone had spotted her climbing those stairs. Her carefully constructed lie was about to collapse, and she would have to face the wreckage of everything she'd built.

"Okay," she said, sitting down.

Cole took her hands in his. His palms were sweaty.

"I talked to your dad last weekend," he said. "When you thought I was at the volunteer thing."

Her heart stopped.

"I drove out to Ohio. Met with him for lunch. Asked his permission."

No.

"Jessa." Cole's eyes were shining now, earnest and hopeful and completely blind to the woman sitting in front of him. "I want to propose. Soon. I've got the ring picked out and everything. I just, I wanted you to know it's coming. So you could prepare. So it could be special."

She only stared at him. She held, squeezed, even kind of stroked another man's bare cock only a few hours earlier.

His face was so open, so trusting. He'd driven six hours to ask her father's permission, because that was what good Christian men did. He'd picked out a ring, probably something modest and tasteful, to be paid for with careful savings. He was sitting on her couch, offering her everything she'd spent her whole life being told she wanted.

But all she could think was: *I was at Jackson's place last night. I came three times. I touched my lips to the tip of the head of his straining hard cock. I fell asleep in his arms and didn't think about you once.*

"Cole," she whispered.

"You don't have to say anything now." He squeezed her hands. "I just wanted you to know. So when it happens, you're ready."

But she wasn't ready. She wasn't ready for any of this.

The ring was in Cole's sock drawer.

Jessa knew because she'd found it accidentally, looking for a phone charger in his apartment while he was in the shower. It was a small velvet box, navy blue, tucked beneath balled-up dress socks like it was the most natural hiding place in the world. She hadn't opened it and she didn't need

to. The shape of it told her everything, Cole's promise made tangible, waiting for the right moment to "change her life forever."

That had been three days ago. She hadn't told Jackson about it.

No, she dressed in secret new underwear and climbed the stairs behind Rosie's on a Thursday night, her legs heavy, her chest tight with what she knew she was going to do. The bar noise faded as she reached his door, and when Jackson opened it, his smile faltered.

"Hey." He stepped aside to let her in. "You okay?"

"Fine."

But she wasn't fine, she was the opposite of fine. She moved past him into the apartment, into the space that had become more familiar to her than her own bedroom, and she stood in the middle of his room not knowing what to do with her body.

Jackson closed the door and watched her.

"Jessa."

"I don't want to talk."

"Okay."

He crossed to the turntable and put something on, not Nina Simone, not Fleetwood Mac, something she didn't recognize with a slow, aching melody that matched the tightness in her throat. Damn him, she thought, he was too good at that. Then he came to stand in front of her, close but not touching, just waiting.

She'd gotten good at reading him over these weeks. The patience in his stillness, the way he never pushed but always paid attention. He knew something was wrong and he was giving her space to tell him or not tell him, and somehow that consideration broke her.

"Cole's going to propose," she said.

The words hung between them like a sheet.

Jackson's expression didn't change, but something shifted behind his eyes. "When?"

"Soon. This week, maybe. I found the ring." She laughed, but it came out broken. "He asked my dad's permission. Drove all the way to Ohio. Because that's what good Christian men do."

"What are you going to say?"

"Yes, of course, I have to." The word tasted like ash. "I'm going to say yes. Because that's what good Christian women do. We say yes. We get married. We have sex for the first time on our wedding night in a hotel

room with rose petals on the bed, and we pretend we don't already know what our bodies can do because knowing would mean we're damaged goods."

She slowly raised her eyes to his and her voice cracked on the last word.

Jackson reached for her, and she let him pull her into his chest. His arms wrapped around her, solid and warm, and she buried her face in his shirt and breathed in the sandalwood and smoke and everything she was about to lose.

"What do you want though?" he asked quietly.

The question was so simple, so obvious. And yet she had no idea how to answer it.

"I just don't know," she whispered. "I've never known. No one ever asked me what I wanted before. They just tell you what your supposed to want, and I wanted it because wanting anything else was never an option."

"It's an option now, maybe."

"Is it though?" She pulled back to look at him. "I'm twenty-five years old. I've been with Cole for two years. My whole family knows him. My church knows him. My life is built around the assumption that I'm going to marry him, and I can't just, I can't..."

She couldn't finish the sentence.

Jackson cupped her face in his hands, those scarred knuckles with history gentle against her cheeks. "You can do whatever you want, Jessa. That's the thing. There's no script. There's no rule book. There's just you, and what you want, and whether you're brave enough to take it."

"I'm not brave enough."

"You're here, aren't you?"

She stared at him. The record crackled and sang in the background. The bar noise pulsed faintly through the floor. She thought about the ring in Cole's sock drawer, the wedding that was coming whether she wanted it or not, the marriage bed where she was supposed to give her husband something she'd pretty much already given away in pieces on this green velvet couch, but the one thing.

"I don't want to belong to him," she said. "I don't want to belong to anyone."

"Then don't."

"It's not that simple."

"I know that." Jackson stroked his thumb across her cheekbone, catching a tear she hadn't realized she'd shed. "But you own it, you know, not him or anyone else. It's yours and only yours."

She knew what he meant. She'd known for weeks that they were building toward this, that every technicality she'd clung to was just a way of delaying the inevitable. The line she'd drawn was arbitrary, meaningless, she'd already betrayed Cole in every way that mattered. The only thing she'd been protecting was her own ability to pretend.

"Yeah," she whispered. "And I want it to be yours," she screamed in her mind.

Jackson kissed her, slow and deep, and she tasted the whiskey on his tongue. His hands found the hem of her shirt and he pulled it up over her head. She reached for his shirt, desperate suddenly to feel his skin against her, kicking her feet the way he made her do that. They undressed each other with an urgency they'd never allowed before, all those nights of grinding and touching and coming without ever crossing the final boundary, and now the boundary was dissolving like it had never existed at all.

Completely naked for the first time with her, he walked her backward toward his bed, not the couch this time, but the actual bed in the corner of the studio, unmade and rumpled and so real. She fell back onto the mattress before him, and he followed her down, his weight settling between her thighs. She could feel him hard against her, nothing between them for the first time, hot and ready.

"Are you sure?" he asked.

"Yes." She tried so hard not to sound desperate. This is no time for niceties, buster, she wanted to growl. She wanted to bite him.

He reached into his nightstand for a condom, tore the wrapper with his teeth, and rolled it on with practiced efficiency, she noted. Then he was there, pressing himself against her entrance, and she was shaking with fear and want and more.

"Look at me," he said.

She did.

He pushed inside her so very slowly, giving her body time to adjust, and the stretch was strange and full and nothing like she'd imagined. It didn't hurt the way her mother had warned it would, she was too aroused for that, too ready after weeks of his hands and mouth preparing her. But it was overwhelming in a different way. The intimacy of it. The irrevocability of it.

She pulled her knees up around his hips, let them fall more widely open. He filled her all the way till his hips gently jolted her hips.

She was having sex, real sex, in a cheap studio apartment above a bar, with a man who wasn't her boyfriend, two months before she was supposed to do this in a marriage bed with rose petals and a white nightgown and a husband who'd waited for her.

A tear ran down her temple.

"Hey." Jackson went still inside her, concern flickering across his face. "We can stop."

"No." She grabbed his hips, pulling him deeper. "Don't stop. More."

He began to move on her.

It was nothing like she'd expected. It was not fumbling or awkward the first time like she'd heard whispered about. It was also not the holy, spiritual union her purity books had promised it would be. It was raw and messy, bodily and real, Jackson thrusting into her with a rhythm that built and built, his mouth on her neck, his hand slipping between them to circle her clit because of course he knew, of course he remembered that she needed that to come.

She curled her fingers around his waist, dug her nails into his skin. She locked her ankles in his back, and curled her toes hard.

Now crying out loud and clutching him like he was the only solid thing in a world that had tilted on its axis, it came upon her so fast, wave after wave of pure pleasure crashing through her while tears streaked her face and she whispered *yes* and *please* and *don't stop* into his ear she couldn't stop biting, and then words that weren't words at all, just sounds, her body speaking a language it had always known.

He paused mid drive, his thing trembling just inside her, and when she chanced to open her eyes from the trance he induced in her, she found him straining, grimacing, his eyes clenched and his body rigid.

"Come, baby," she said softly. "Inside me."

He plunged into her so hard the whole bed bounced with their thrusting bodies, her slamming up into his as hard as he slammed down into hers. Its feet skidded over the floor, the headboard banged the wall, the slap of their bodies echoed through the place, and she cried out loud because she couldn't hold back anymore.

She felt him gush into her. It made her back arch impossibly deep. He collapsed on her full weight, and she absorbed him, kissed him all over,

wrapped herself around him with all her limbs might.

When he finished, he groaned her name into her shoulder, and she held him there, feeling him pulse inside her still, and she combed his sweating hair with her fingers and soothed him with kisses down his neck.

The room went quiet except for their breathing and the skip of the needle at the end of the record.

She was no longer a virgin. She was no longer saving herself. She was just a woman in a bed, having done the thing she'd promised God and her parents and Cole she wouldn't do. But she felt, for the first time in her life, completely like a woman. They at least got that part right, she laughed.

"What's so funny?" Jackson said, too sleepy to lift his face from her neck.

"You're funny," she said, and when he made to pull out of her, she gripped his ass to make him stay a little bit longer.

The morning light was unforgiving.

Jessa woke in Jackson's bed with her body aching in unfamiliar places, her thighs sticky, her neck tender where his mouth had been. He was still asleep beside her, one arm thrown across her waist, his breathing slow and even. She studied his face in the gray dawn, the stubble, the faint lines around his eyes, the mouth that had learned every inch of her body, and felt something twist in her chest.

She slipped out from under his arm and gathered her clothes from the floor.

In the bathroom mirror, she gathered the evidence. A bruise blooming on her collarbone, redness on her inner thighs from his stubble, her lips swollen, her hair tangled, her eyes holding fire that hadn't been there yesterday.

She looked like a woman who'd been thoroughly fucked, because she had been. Three times, the last one slow and almost sweet, Jackson moving inside her while she cried for reasons she couldn't explain.

She rode him while he reached up and squeezed her breasts, and she stretched back until he dragged his thumb over her clit and she laughed and squealed at him about trying to make her come, which she did.

She laughed and padded around his place naked getting water and slurping noodles and she teased him with her mouth, but got too shy to take him all the way in.

She dressed quietly and let herself out without waking him.

The drive home was silent, the radio off, her hands steady on the wheel despite the tremors running through the rest of her body. She parked in her usual spot and climbed the stairs to her apartment and stood under the shower until she turned to a prune, but she couldn't wash away the feeling of him, the soreness, the strange hollow ache between her legs, the reminder with every step of what she'd done.

Her phone buzzed while she was toweling off her hair with a grin she couldn't wipe off as easily as her thighs.

Cole: *Mom wants to take us to dinner tonight. 7pm at Marcello's. Can you make it?*

Marcello's was Cole's mother's favorite restaurant, all white tablecloths, overpriced pasta, the kind of place you went for celebrations. Jessa stared at the message and felt the pieces click into place, Cole's nervousness lately, the ring in the sock drawer, his mother's sudden dinner invitation.

He was going to propose tonight. And his mother already knew.

Sure, she typed back. *Sounds great*. What could she say?

She spent the day in a daze, moving through her apartment like a ghost. She did laundry. She cleaned the bathroom. She sat on her couch and stared at nothing, replaying the night before in a loop she couldn't escape, Jackson's hands on her hips, Jackson pulling her down onto him, the sound Jackson made when he came. The way he held her afterward, not asking for explanations, not demanding promises, just *present* in a way Cole had never been.

At six, she put on a modest dress that covered any remaining evidence and drove to Marcello's.

Cole's mother was already there, seated at a corner table with a bottle of champagne sweating in an ice bucket. She rose when Jessa approached, her face radiant with barely contained excitement, and pulled Jessa into a hug that smelled like Chanel No. 5 and hairspray.

"There she is," Carol said, gripping Jessa's shoulders. "Oh, honey. I'm so happy for you both."

Jessa's smile felt like a stiff, cracking mask. "Thank you."

Cole kissed her cheek, that same chaste brush of lips, that same familiar nothing, and pulled out her chair like the gentleman he'd been raised to be. He was nervous, she could tell. His knee bounced under the table. His laugh came too quickly at his mother's jokes.

"I know Cole wanted to wait," Carol said, pouring champagne into three glasses, "but I just couldn't help myself. When he told me he'd gotten your father's blessing, I cried for an hour. An *hour*, Jessa. You're the daughter I always wanted."

Jessa accepted the glass, though she didn't drink. The bubbles rose in a steady stream, golden and festive, celebrating something that had already been ruined. But ruined so good...

"He's planning something special for this weekend," Carol continued, leaning in conspiratorially. "I'm not supposed to say anything, but, well. You'll want to get your nails done. Trust me."

"Mom." Cole's face was red. "You're ruining it."

"I'm not ruining anything! I'm just making sure she's ready. A girl wants to look her best for the biggest moment of her life."

The biggest moment of her life. Jessa thought about last night, Jackson pushing inside her for the first time, the stretch of him, and the fullness, the way she'd gasped and clung to him while her whole understanding of herself got rearranged. *That* had been the biggest moment of her life. Everything else was just aftermath.

"I'm so excited," she said, because it was what Carol wanted to hear. "I've been hoping for this."

"Of course you have! Two years is long enough to wait. You two are perfect for each other. Everyone says so."

Dinner proceeded in a blur of breadsticks and pasta and Carol's enthusiastic monologue about wedding venues and color schemes and the importance of booking a photographer early. Cole interjected occasionally, embarrassed but pleased, his hand finding Jessa's under the table and squeezing.

She squeezed back. It was what she was supposed to do.

But her phone buzzed against her thigh. Jessa glanced down, keeping her face neutral, and saw Jackson's name on the screen.

No regrets?

Two words. A question that demanded honesty. From a man who deserved it.

She looked up at Cole across the table, at his earnest face and his hopeful eyes and his complete ignorance of who she'd become. He was already planning their wedding in his head, she could see it in the way he smiled at his mother's suggestions, the way he nodded along to discussions

of seating charts and invitation fonts. He was picturing their wedding night, probably. The moment he'd finally get to touch her the way he'd been waiting to touch her for two years. The gift she'd been saving for him...

Except she hadn't saved it. She'd given it away in a studio apartment above a bar, to a man with scarred hands and whiskey on his breath, and she'd cried while she came and felt more alive than she'd ever felt in her entire carefully controlled life.

Carol was talking about bridesmaids now, suggesting Jessa's sister for maid of honor, wondering if four months was enough time to plan, or if they should aim for six.

Under the table, Jessa's thumbs moved across her phone screen.

None. What. So. Eva. She added a happy emoji with hearts buzzing around the head.

She sent the message and slipped the phone back into her purse, her face arranged in an expression of attentive joy. Carol reached across the table to clasp her hand, eyes shining with tears.

"Welcome to the family, sweetheart. Officially. Or almost officially."

"Thank you," Jessa said. "I can't wait."

Cole beamed at her, his whole future written in his smile. The house they'd buy. The children they'd have. The marriage that would unfold in proper Christian order, blessed by the church and sanctioned by God.

Jessa smiled back, and said yes to all of it, and felt the weight of her lie evaporate like morning dew from the rising sun.

She could marry Cole, she could stand at the altar and promise herself to him. She could go to their marriage bed and pretend it was her first time, could let him believe he was taking something precious, something saved just for him.

But she would carry Jackson with her forever, the taste of him, the feel of him, the memory of what it meant to want something so badly you could burn your whole life down to have it.

No regrets?

"Well?" his mother said to Cole.

Cole blushed and took a deep breath. He raised his eyebrows, pretending this was some big telling moment, like there was an actual decision to be made. He grinned at Jessa with all his teeth, perfect white and even. She glanced down and saw his smooth, slender, and unscarred hand reach into his pocket.

She seized his wrist. “Wait! Bathroom!” and she flung herself out of her chair and made her quick way to the back.

Cole’s mother was dying with the romance of it. Cole’s breath was hyperventilating with it.

But past the bathrooms was the emergency exit, and the bar across it triggered an alarm as she burst out and onto a catwalk of metalwork, the sun blinding her, the steel of the railing cold and hard, and she stumbled down the steps barely staying upright, went head down over the heat-waving pavement, heard Cole above call her, his mother call her louder, confused, until she made the turn, found her car, pushed her palms across her eyes enough to see the ignition button, and squealed the wheels when she took off down the street.

And headed straight for Jackson’s bar. She strode through it and he looked up from cleaning taps, saw her dive through the back door, nodded at the server, and dropped his apron on the stool.

He came through his open door tentatively but Jessa dropped on her knees, dug with frustration at his belt and jeans, yanked his pants down and consumed him to the back of her throat.

Jackson finished tidying the bar and made his way upstairs. Jessa timed it right, eggs and toast were ready for him.

Sated and collapsing on his couch, Jessa curling up with him, he said, “You get out today?”

She only shook her head and undid his pants.

“It’s been three days. You answer your phone yet?”

“Mm-mm,” she said, licking him his full length, kissing him, taking him deeply.

He drew her hair out of her face and tucked it around her ear. “You have to do something at some point.”

She got off the couch, tossed his t-shirt up and over her head, drew her panties down her legs, and came to straddle him, reaching behind herself to aim him, taking him inside her with a gasp.

“At some point,” she said with a groan. “Mister Man,” she added, and she swirled her hot tongue around his lips and grinded herself down into him.